

Work Meaning and Fair Wages

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BEHCHA Workshop Cagliari



Introduction

- ▶ Labor supply is falling in most developed countries:
 - intensive margin on long-term decline
 - participation of women stagnated / is decreasing for men

→ **shortages** in **labor supply**
- ▶ What motivates people to accept a job offer?
 - wages but also non-monetary component
 - amenities valued at up to 50% of compensation in [Maestas et al. \(2023\)](#)
 - we study **work meaning**: “importance of a job for others or society”

This paper

- (1) How does **work meaning** relate to **labor supply**?
- (2) Whether and how does this relation **differ** across people?
→ particularly the role of **fairness concerns**

Meaning and Labor Supply – Mixed Evidence

- + Work meaning **increases** labor supply:
or individuals (want to) sacrifice wages for meaning
 - surveys: many people indicate care about work meaning
 - Dur and van Lent (2019), Kesternich *et al.* (2021) & Burbano *et al.* (2024)
 - experiments: meaning increases labor supply and effort
 - Ariely *et al.* (2008) and Burbano (2016)
 - admin data: $\uparrow$ socially responsible organizations earn $\downarrow$ wages
 - Nyborg and Zhang (2013), Krueger *et al.* (2023) & Schneider *et al.* (2024)
- Work meaning has **no (or a small) effect** on labor supply
 - wages in non-profit $\approx$ for-profit
 - Leete (2001) & Jones (2015)
 - experiments: both positive and negative responses to $\uparrow$ meaning
 - Kesternich *et al.* (2021)
 - willingness to pay is small vs. other amenities like flexibility
 - Maestas *et al.* (2023) & De Schouwer and Kesternich (forthcoming)

Introducing Fairness Concerns

- ▶ We argue **fairness** aspect to meaning has been overlooked
 - creating benefits for others has important fairness dimension:
"I should get a share of the benefits I create!"
 - workers reduce effort and labor supply when treated unfairly
 - Akerlof (1982), Fehr *et al.* (1993) & Krueger and Friebe (2022)
- ▶ Connect meaning and fairness in a simple **model** of **labor supply**
- ▶ Test model **predictions** on collected survey-experimental data:
 - (1) significant share of individuals for whom work meaning **increases** and significant share for whom meaning **decreases** labor supply
 - (2) these **reactions correlate** with an individual's **fairness concerns**

Preview of Results

Three main empirical findings:

- (1) Work meaning has a **small** (positive) **impact** on **labor supply**
 - $\approx 4\%$ reduction in reservation wage
 - similar to previous studies such as [Maestas et al. \(2023\)](#)
- (2) Effect driven by a **minority** of subjects who **react positively**
 - about 40% of respondents would accept lower reservation wage
 - but 20% of respondents would demand a *higher* reservation wage
 - substantial heterogeneity by demographics
- (3) Strong **negative** association WtP for meaning & **fairness concerns**

Outline

- 1 Labor Supply Model
- 2 Survey and Experiment
- 3 Results
- 4 Conclusion

Labor Supply Model

Labor Supply Model

- ▶ Consider labor supply model where (reservation) wages are:
 - a function of preferences for **work meaning**
 - introduce similar to [Cassar and Meier \(2018\)](#)
 - a function of **fairness concerns**
 - introduce similar to [Cappelen et al. \(2007\)](#)
- ▶ The **utility** of a worker that accepts a job offer at wage w :

$$U(w, x) = w + \theta m(x) - \alpha(\pi^f(x) - w)^2 - c, \quad (1)$$

- x are benefits created for others
- $m(\cdot)$ is generated amount of meaning
- $\pi^f(\cdot)$ is wage the worker considers fair
- c are cost of doing the job
- θ and α are preferences for work meaning and fairness

Labor Supply Model

- ▶ Assume that both meaning m and the fair wage π^f **increase** in x
 - the latter follows from fair wage increasing in the surplus π
 - consistent with broad set of views on fairness: the egalitarian, meritocratic & libertarian ideals of Cappelen *et al.* (2007)
- ▶ Workers **accept** job offer if it exceeds reservation utility $\bar{U}$:

$$U(w, x) \geq \bar{U} \quad (2)$$

- ▶ The **reservation wage** w^* is the smallest w that satisfies (2)

Labor Supply Model

Proposition I:

Suppose fair wage weakly exceeds the reservation wage w^* .

- (1) a change in **work meaning** can **increase** or **decrease** w^*
 - the sign depends on relative strength of:
 - meaning preferences: θ
 - fairness concerns: α
 - there is a threshold ξ^* s.t. an increase in benefits for others:
 - decreases w^* if we have $\frac{\theta}{\alpha} > \xi^*$
 - increases w^* if we have $\frac{\theta}{\alpha} < \xi^*$
- (2) a **reduction in the cost** of doing the job (c) **reduces** w^*

Labor Supply Model

- ▶ We identify fairness concerns through an **Ultimatum Game**:
 - an employer (= dictator) splits profits between himself and a worker
 - the worker can choose to accept or reject the offered wages w_{UG}
 - denote by w_{UG}^* the smallest offer a workers accepts
- ▶ Abstracting from meaning and costs w_{UG}^* is determined by:

$$w_{UG} - \alpha(\pi^f - w_{UG})^2 = 0 \quad (3)$$

Proposition II:

Suppose the fair offer weakly exceeds the Ultimatum Game offer.

A marginal increase in **fairness concerns** α will **increase** the **reservation wage** w_{UG}^* .

Survey and Experiment

Table of Content

- 1 Labor Supply Model
- 2 Survey and Experiment
- 3 Results
- 4 Conclusion

Experimental Design

- ▶ We want to know how **labor supply changes** when:
 - the characteristics of a **job vary** (e.g., benefits created)
 - elicit reservation wages under varying job descriptions
 - through a variation on standard elicitation procedure
 - the characteristics of a **worker vary** (e.g., fairness concerns)
 - elicit fairness concerns through an ultimatum game
 - collect data on potential sources of heterogeneity
- ▶ The elicitation procedure allows us to introduce different **treatments** – which we assign randomly across respondents:
 - 1 meaning treatments
 - 2 profit treatments
 - 3 flexibility treatments

Experimental Design

Q1 Expected wage

"We are interested in what you expect to be a realistic net monthly salary. Thus, we mean the salary you would expect from an employer net of all deductions and taxes/levies. Suppose you had to search for a full-time job next month.

What do you think would be a **realistic net monthly salary** for 38 hours of work per week, considering your qualifications and your experience? [**Answer:** w Euro]"

Q2 Reservation wage

"How much would the monthly net wage have to be as a **minimum**, for you to be willing to take the job?" [**Answer:** w^* Euro]"

Experimental Design

Q3 Reservation wage – Meaning Treatment

"You stated that for a 38 hour work week the minimum net monthly salary you would want to earn is w^* Euro.

Now imagine that the job you are considering directly or indirectly helps needy (sick or elderly or poor) people, children or the environment. This job is the same as your previous one, but through your work you now provide direct or indirect help to others or the environment (e.g., in terms of education, health, or environmental protection). **Suppose these additional benefits (to sick, poor or elderly people, children or the environment) are equivalent to X Euro per month.**

Can you imagine taking this job **even if your salary would be less than w^* Euro?**" [Answer: 'Yes' / 'No']

Experimental Design

Q4.1a **Decrease wage demand.** if 'Yes' to Q3

"How much less than w^ Euro could your net monthly wage be in order for you to take this job with direct or indirect benefits for needy (sick or elderly or poor) people, children or the environment?"* [**Answer:** Δ_l Euro]

Q4.1b **Don't decrease wage demand.** if 'No' to Q3

"Please indicate which of the following applies to you."
[**Answer:** 'I would take this job **at the salary** of w^* Euro' **or** 'I would take this job only if the salary was **higher** than w^* Euro']

Q4.2b **Increase wage demand.** if '...higher...' to Q4.1b

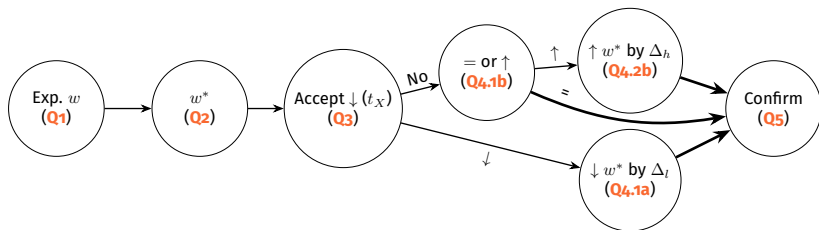
"How much more than w^ Euro must your net monthly wage be in order for you to take this job with direct or indirect benefits for needy (sick or elderly or poor) people, children or the environment?"* [**Answer:** Δ_h Euro]

Experimental Design

Q5 Confirmation.

"You indicated that you would require at least a salary of $w^* - \Delta_l$ / $w^* / w^* + \Delta_h$ to accept a job where you directly or indirectly help needy (sick or elderly or poor) people, children or the environment. **Is that correct?**" [Answer: 'Yes' or 'No, I want to change my reply']

Figure: Overview of Elicitation Procedure



Experimental Design

- ▶ With this procedure we elicit for each *individual* both:
 - the **reservation wage**: w^*
 - the **reservation wage** for the **updated job**: w^{**}
 - $w^{**} = w^* - \Delta_l$ or $w^{**} = w^* + \Delta_h$

→ within subject estimates allow study WtP **distribution**
- ▶ The values for X are different **amounts** or a **neutral** treatment:
 - monetary amount: 100 – 1,000 – 10,000 – 100,000 Euro
 - neutral treatment: no money mentioned
- ▶ The **profit** and **flexibility** treatments mention:
 - "Now imagine the job increases your employer's profits.."
 - "Now imagine the job offers..":
 - 20 minutes shorter commute daily (round trip)
 - one additional paid day of working from home (per week)
 - one additional unpaid day off (per month)

Additional Survey Questions

- ▶ Measure **fairness** concerns with a hypothetical ultimatum game
- ▶ Questions on **social preferences**
 - altruism, reciprocity and trust
 - asked as in Global Preference Survey (GPS)
- ▶ Questions several **demographics**
 - gender, age, occupation, etc.
- ▶ In **representative samples** from NL (LISS) and Germany (Bilendi)
 - $\approx$ 3,500 respondents in NL
 - $\approx$ 5,500 respondents in Germany
 - summary statistics / balancing

Hypotheses

- Main outcome of interest is **Willingness to Pay** for job variation t_X :

$$\text{WtP}_{t_X} = \frac{w^* - w_{t_X}^{**}}{w^*} \quad (4)$$

Hypotheses:

H1 In each meaning treatment, there is a share of respondents with a **positive WtP** for work meaning and a share of respondents with a **negative WtP** for work meaning.

H2 For any given X the following **ordering** holds on the WtP:

$$\text{WtP}_{\text{Meaning}_X} > \text{WtP}_{\text{Profit}_X} \text{ and } \text{WtP}_{\text{Flexibility}} > 0.$$

H3 In each meaning treatment, respondents with **high fairness** concerns have a **lower WtP for meaning** than respondents with **low fairness** concerns.

Results

Results

- (1) Look at the **Willingness to Pay** for job variations
- (2) Then consider how this **WtP** relates to **fairness concerns**
- (3) Next we look at **heterogeneity** between subgroups
- (4) Several **robustness** checks

Willingness to Pay – the Netherlands

	(1) w_t^* in k Euro	(2) WtP _t	(3) % WtP _t > 0	(4) % WtP _t = 0	(5) % WtP _t < 0
Meaning-Neutral	2.551	4.9** (1.9)	42.8	33.9	22.3
Meaning-100	2.569	7.0*** (2.2)	46.9	29.7	23.5
Meaning-1k	2.602	2.5 (1.7)	35.5	42.8	21.7
Meaning-10k	2.607	2.5 (2.5)	43.7	30.8	25.4
Meaning-100k	2.590	10.1*** (1.9)	46.7	35.2	18.0
Meaning (all)	2.584	5.4*** (0.9)	43.0	34.7	22.3

Standard errors in brackets. Two-sided t-tests of WtP_t being mean zero.
Significance at * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$.

Willingness to Pay – Germany

	(1) w_t^* in k Euro	(2) WtP _t	(3) % WtP _t > 0	(4) % WtP _t = 0	(5) % WtP _t < 0
Meaning-Neutral	2.438	5.1** (2.1)	42.2	36.2	21.7
Meaning-1k	2.446	0.2 (1.8)	34.1	47.0	18.9
Meaning-10k	2.445	3.5 (2.2)	40.6	35.6	23.7
Meaning (all)	2.443	3.0** (1.2)	39.1	39.4	21.5
Profit-Neutral	2.465	-6.7*** (2.2)	27.0	33.2	39.8
Profit-1k	2.504	-4.3** (2.2)	26.1	41.6	32.2
Profit-10k	2.470	-8.6*** (2.3)	24.1	37.0	38.9
Profit (all)	2.480	-6.5*** (1.3)	25.7	37.3	37.0
Flexibility	2.366	11.0*** (2.0)	43.7	35.3	21.0

Standard errors in brackets. Two-sided t-tests of WtP_t being mean zero. Significance at * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$.

Recap on Willingness to Pay

- ▶ Average **WtP** pay for meaning is **positive** in both countries
 - estimates of 3 to 5.4% close to recent discrete choice experiments
 - [Maestas et al. \(2023\)](#) find 3.5% in the United States
 - [De Schouwer and Kesternich \(forthcoming\)](#) find 6% in the Netherlands
 - but the effect is driven by a **minority** of respondents ($\approx 40\%$)
 - ➔ substantial fraction demands higher wages when meaning increases
- ▶ Respondents request **higher wages** if job generates **higher profits**
 - but a significant minority positive WtP for employer's profits
 - perhaps: job security, dynamic incentives, non-profit organizations
- ▶ The WtP for **flexibility** is the largest
 - 11% in line with 6-8% in [Mas and Pallais \(2017\)](#) & [Aksoy et al. \(2022\)](#)
 - but still substantial fraction (21%) demands wage *increase*
 - similar to [Aksoy et al. \(2022\)](#)'s 16% $\uparrow$ for more WFH

Fairness Concerns

► Hypothetical **dictator** game:

- we give another person 20 Euro to share with you.
- you can accept or reject the division the other person proposes
- if you reject the division, no one gets any money
- subjects can indicate whether accept or reject several divisions
- division are: other person offers 0, 2, 4, 6, 8, or 10 Euro

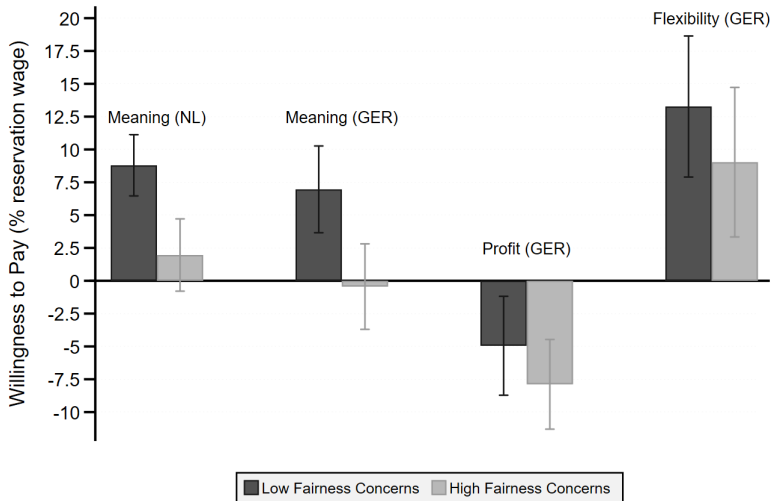
Table: Distribution of Fairness Concerns

	implied UG-reservation wage	<i>The Netherlands</i> (LISS)	<i>Germany</i> (Bilendi)
Accept all offers	0 Euro	30.1	18.7
Reject one offer	2 Euro	6.9	9.8
Reject two offers	4 Euro	3.8	6.3
Reject three offers	6 Euro	9.9	11.6
Reject four offers	8 Euro	18.3	17.4
Reject five offers	10 Euro	30.4	34.9
Reject all six offers	> 10 Euro	0.7	1.2



Higher
Fairness
Concerns

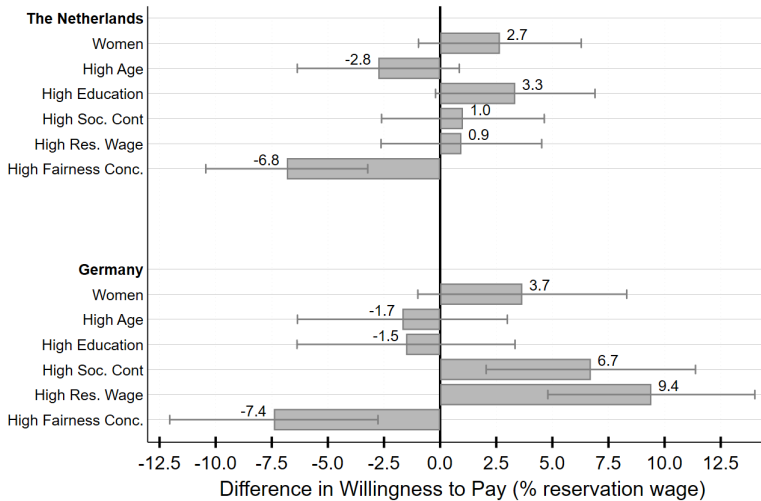
Willingness to Pay and Fairness Concerns



Recap on WtP and Fairness Concerns

- ▶ **Lower fairness** concerns → **higher** WtP for **meaning**
 - in the Netherlands: 8.8% vs. 2.0%
 - in Germany: 7.4% vs. -0.4%
 - differences significant at the 5% level
- ▶ Substantially smaller differences in WtP for **Flexibility** and **Profits**
 - higher fairness concerns slight ↓ WtP for profits
 - higher fairness concerns slight ↓ WtP for flexibility
 - smaller and not statistically significant

Heterogeneity



Recap on Heterogeneity

- ▶ **Higher** WtP among **women** than men in both samples
 - in line with literature such as [Burbano et al. \(2024\)](#)
- ▶ Small age and education effects
 - slight decrease with age
 - education effects contrast
- ▶ WtP increases in (self-stated) **societal contributions** (small in NL)
 - labor market sorting on meaning
- ▶ WtP increases in **reservation wages** (small in NL)

Robustness and More Heterogeneity

- ▶ Results on fairness hold in **regressions**:
 - the Netherlands
 - Germany
- ▶ Results on fairness hold in **discrete choice** experiment
 - available for the Netherlands
- ▶ Importance of social preferences
 - particularly: altruism $\times$ fairness
- ▶ Several **other** robustness **checks**:
 - data cleaning procedures: failing attention check or outliers in w^*
 - continuous fairness and control variable measures
 - replacing WtP with a positive/negative valuation indicator

Conclusion

Conclusion

- ▶ We examine the **Willingness to Pay** for **work meaning**
- ▶ The average WtP is relatively **small** but **positive** and significant
 - roughly 4% of the reservation wage
 - slightly lower than for flexibility
- ▶ This positive average masks $\approx 20\%$ of **negative** valuations
- ▶ We find a robust connection between **meaning** & **fairness concerns**

Thank you for listening!

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Appendix – Treatments and Main Demographics

Country (Survey) Treatment	N	Share Females	Age (sd)	Share High Education	Reservation Wage in <i>k</i> Euro (sd)
<i>The Netherlands (LISS)</i>					
Meaning-Neutral	472	0.554	46.22 (12.76)	0.464	2.551 (0.624)
Meaning-100	429	0.578	45.97 (12.60)	0.429	2.569 (0.603)
Meaning-1k	479	0.557	46.82 (13.01)	0.418	2.602 (0.625)
Meaning-10k	455	0.556	47.03 (12.74)	0.455	2.607 (0.583)
Meaning-100k	488	0.547	46.43 (13.35)	0.465	2.590 (0.590)
diff. <i>p</i> -value		0.911	0.729	0.468	0.580
<i>Germany (Bilendi)</i>					
Meaning-Neutral	448	0.518	42.17 (14.02)	0.321	2.437 (0.714)
Meaning-1k	413	0.530	43.35 (13.43)	0.322	2.445 (0.681)
Meaning-10k	438	0.537	43.02 (14.00)	0.342	2.444 (0.686)
Profit-Neutral	422	0.528	41.50 (13.92)	0.341	2.465 (0.671)
Profit-1k	425	0.553	42.37 (13.06)	0.318	2.504 (0.738)
Profit-10k	427	0.595	42.53 (13.55)	0.344	2.469 (0.690)
Flexibility	443	0.549	41.53 (13.63)	0.330	2.366 (0.674)
diff. <i>p</i> -value		0.352	0.328	0.961	0.136

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Regressions – the Netherlands

	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>Demographic Variables</i>			
Gender	0.025 (0.018)	0.023 (0.018)	0.024 (0.019)
High Age	-0.021 (0.019)	-0.015 (0.019)	-0.015 (0.019)
High Education	0.028 (0.018)	0.021 (0.018)	0.019 (0.020)
<i>Job Variables</i>			
High Societal Contributions			0.002 (0.019)
High Reservation Wage			0.005 (0.020)
<i>Fairness Concerns</i>			
High Fairness Concerns		-0.065*** (0.019)	-0.064*** (0.019)
<i>Treatments</i>			
Meaning-100	0.021 (0.030)	0.021 (0.030)	0.020 (0.030)
Meaning-1k	-0.023 (0.026)	-0.023 (0.026)	-0.023 (0.026)
Meaning-10k	-0.024 (0.031)	-0.023 (0.031)	-0.023 (0.031)
Meaning-100k	0.052* (0.027)	0.055** (0.027)	0.055** (0.027)
Constant	0.033 (0.026)	0.065** (0.027)	0.063** (0.029)
Observations	2323	2323	2323
R ²	0.007	0.012	0.012

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Regressions – Germany

	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>Demographic Variables</i>			
Gender	0.035 (0.024)	0.033 (0.023)	0.045* (0.023)
High Age	-0.018 (0.025)	-0.008 (0.026)	-0.016 (0.025)
High Education	-0.020 (0.026)	-0.024 (0.026)	-0.050* (0.026)
<i>Job Variables</i>			
High Societal Contributions			0.058*** (0.024)
High Reservation Wage			0.109*** (0.024)
<i>Fairness Concerns</i>			
High Fairness Concerns		-0.076*** (0.024)	-0.074*** (0.024)
<i>Treatments</i>			
Meaning-1k	-0.049* (0.028)	-0.053** (0.028)	-0.056* (0.028)
Meaning-10k	-0.016 (0.030)	-0.018 (0.028)	-0.018 (0.030)
Constant	0.049 (0.030)	0.088*** (0.032)	-0.020 (0.034)
Observations	1299	1299	1299
R^2	0.005	0.012	0.033

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WtP in Choice Experiment I

- ▶ The WtP elicitation procedure is **noisy**:
 - respondents answer with monetary amounts
 - not everyone will understand the question
- ▶ More standard approach relies on a **discrete choice** experiments
 - benefit of greatly reducing noise
 - but: only averages vs. individual level estimates
 - and: typically redraw 'dominated' choices
 - i.e. by design do not allow negative valuations
- ▶ We ran a discrete choice experiment in LISS one year earlier
 - can merge in respondents' fairness concerns

WtP in Choice Experiment II

Imagine applying for a new job and having to choose between the following two positions. Please assume that both positions are equal in all aspects except for those highlighted below. Please indicate which job you would prefer.

	Job A	Job B
Weekly hours	38	38
Possibility to change work schedule	No	No
Possibility to telecommute	Yes	Yes
Positive impact on society or community	Almost Never	Often
Monthly gross wage (in €)	€2,500	€2,200
<i>Preferred Job</i>	☐	☐

WtP in Choice Experiment III

	Low Fairness	High Fairness	<i>p</i> -value
Work Meaning	7.7*** (0.7)	3.4*** (0.7)	0.000
<i>Workplace Flexibility</i>			
Schedule Adaptability	7.8*** (0.8)	6.2*** (0.8)	0.075
Telecommuting	6.9*** (0.7)	6.5*** (0.7)	0.333

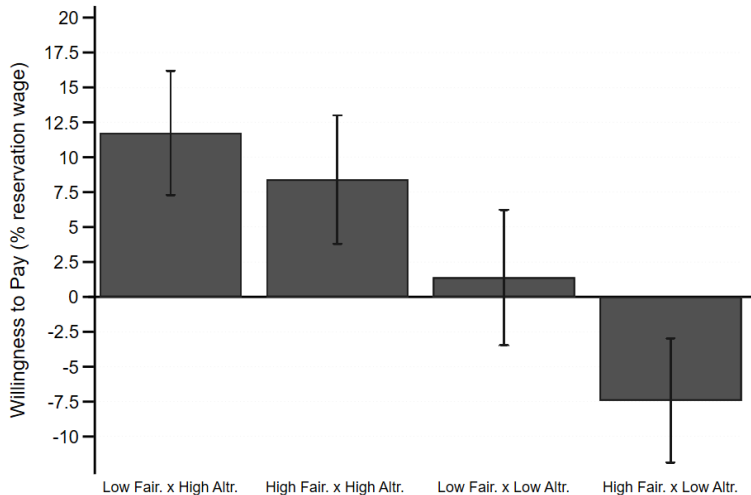
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WtP and Social Preferences (Germany)

<i>Demographic Variables</i>	✓
<i>Job Variables</i>	✓
High Fairness Concerns	-0.054** (0.024)
High Altruism	0.105*** (0.025)
High Positive Reciprocity	0.028 (0.024)
High Negative Reciprocity	-0.015 (0.024)
High Trust	0.082*** (0.025)
<i>Treatments</i>	✓
<i>Constant</i>	✓
Observations	1299
R^2	0.061

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Wtp for Altruism $\times$ Fairness



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